Commentary

The genre I have chosen for both pieces of my original writing coursework is short-story fiction. I wrote both pieces, “Best of Three” and “The Old Man”, to be very similar in terms of context in order to emphasise the difference between the audiences. The content of each story is related, as both share an underlying semantic field of the personification of Death, and how each character would face 'it'. However, “Best of Three” is aimed at young adults (particularly those who enjoy a sudden turn of events for comedic effect), whereas, “The Old Man” is a short story aimed primarily at adults, with a secondary audience of children. This is because parents tend to read fairy tales, even the grim ones, to children so that they learn the important morals seeded within them. Having this scenario, where a parent is reading to their child, meant that I could have darker biblical references in the story that the adult would understand but the child would take no notice of; thus, making it enjoyable for both audiences. Since the genre and semantic field are the same, it allows me to demonstrate how I used different literary techniques to accommodate (H.Giles, 1970s) for each audience.

A key feature used in both pieces is the anthropomorphic personification of Death, but in “The Old Man” this is extended to the Four Horsemen (e.g. “He had witnessed War, shook hands with Pestilence and cursed Famine..”), as mentioned in King James' version of 'Revelation 6', and Johnny Cash's song 'When The Man Comes Around' (“Behold a pale horse: and his name that sat on him was Death, and Hell followed him”). To begin with, in the drafting process, I did not treat “Pestilence”, for example, as a proper noun. However, I decided when discussing the personified version, it should be known as “Pestilence” rather than “disease” to emphasise this archaic feature of language and its importance when portraying a non-concrete concept. This abstract concept had to be implied (Grice, 1980s) in “The Old Man” as it might be seen as ethically wrong by parents to expose their children to such grim ideologies. Therefore, referencing the Four Horsemen was far subtler such as describing Famine as “a fat man” which is a description that a child would be able to comprehend. On the other hand, in “Best of Three”, I could make it obvious that Death was gambling with two beggars, and it needed not flout any of Grice's Maxims, as young adults are very capable of dealing with (and most likely have already been exposed to) the concepts of death and poverty.

I used bathos (much like my style model: Terry Pratchett) in “Best of Three” to build up tension and then reveal a much less impressive ending to create humour (adding to the entertaining purpose). I couldn't use this in “The Old Man” as children wouldn't quite understand why this anti-climax is humorous. Tension builds with the use of minor sentence structures (e.g. “Bones. Skeletons. Dead. Death. It was Death. Death himself.”). Then the reader anticipates an important pivot in the story to reveal a mystery behind the protagonist's motives, when in fact they are playing an unusually competitive game of snap. It's underwhelming, and so it makes the reader laugh.

Another feature that I could only incorporate into “Best of Three” is spelling phonetically (non-standard orthography) to convey accents in an almost transcript-like manner, as well as for humour (further adding to the entertainment element of the piece). I could not add this to “The Old Man” because children being read to by their parents are most likely in the earlier stages of learning how to read and write (Kroll, Barclay), and if they follow the words as their parents speak, they might get confused when it comes to the phonetic spelling and it is possible that it might affect their learning. Pratchett was known for using names that had no apparent connection to the plot, but were in fact spelt phonetically to disclose something about the storyline (e.g. “Schüschein” says “Shoeshine”). I adopted this to allude to the previous downfall of one of the characters hence the city name “Atrufi” (“Atrophy” spelt phonetically; which is a synonym of “Downfall”). I did not incorporate this into “The Old Man” as I believed it already had enough implicature.

“The Old Man” follows a distinctive narrative structure (also present in Daniel Morden's 'Dark Tales from the Woods'), that uses collocations and discourse markers such as “Once upon a time” and repeated sentences (e.g. “You sir! Please spare some...”) that children recognise. Using elements of storytelling that children would recognise engages them, and grabs their attention so that they can be entertained by what they're hearing. Since I use this conventional structure, I also use standard graphology, and as to also not negatively affect the child's learning and (after originally including capitalisation of certain words during the drafting process) made a conscious decision not to add any unusual typographic features in the final piece. “Best of Three” contrasts with this as it's for an older audience, and so I merged Pratchett's capitalisation of Death's speech with my own writing to distinguish between Death's and the mortal men's voices (e.g. “I HAVEN'T MUCH TO SAY ON THAT TOPIC.”) However, I used it differently to Pratchett as in his novels; the reader tends to be aware that it is Death speaking, whereas in mine it is unknown to the reader until the end of the story. Therefore, it's used to alert the reader that one of the three characters is unusual, but it is rare that they will work out why.

Word count: 894